

mythology. It is the wildest and greatest of all Sibelius's nature evocations and is, at the same time, a supreme feat of closely worked orchestral mastery.

“ Music begins where the possibilities of language end. ”

JEAN SIBELIUS, 1919

A long silence

Sibelius's famous “creative silence” from then on was never complete; minor works sometimes appeared, and he revised or orchestrated some of his earlier music. Yet between *Tapiola* in 1926 and his death 31 years later, he released no major new work. In the late 1920s, he was busy with an Eighth Symphony, but no manuscript existed at his death. It is believed that Sibelius destroyed it, but the reasons for this are not known—most likely a combination of self-criticism (always extreme, in his case) and the pressures of international fame.

Following his death, Sibelius's music was increasingly regarded as old-fashioned, and today is not as widely performed in concerts as it once was. However, a huge recorded catalog indicates that his work continues to be much loved by classical music listeners throughout the world.